FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

At one glance, the two assembly election results on October 8 have the appearance of parity. But look closely, and a strong asymmetry reveals itself. What the Narendra Modi-led Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) takes away is in stark contrast to what has befallen its principal rival, the Congress. Morale and momentum have been granted back to the party that rules from New Delhi, and rudely broken for the one that wishes to get there. This is key because Haryana and the Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir were not just one-off matches. They are Round 1 in an ongoing national round robin league: the crucial battlegrounds of Maharashtra and Jharkhand come up within weeks. So the strategies deployed in Haryana and J&K, in terms of their success or lack of it, have a direct bearing on the future.

For the BJP, its unprecedented third straight win in Haryana isn't something even party loyalists may have dared to envisage. This is a heartland state tied in many ways to present-day political dynamics in India, so it can conceivably look to replicate the tactical template it adopted. How did it rustle up 48 seats, in a 90-seat assembly, against an unfavourable wave? It played up the spectre of dominant caste dictatorship. In a judo tactic, the domineering power of Jat titan Bhupinder Singh Hooda was used against the Congress, setting off a silent counter-mobilisation among non-Jats, well over 75 per cent of the electorate. It decentralised ticket distribution, allowing free rein to local strongmen like Rao Inderjit Singh and Union minister Krishan Pal Gurjar. In all, it gave non-Jat OBCs like Yadavs and Gujjars 22 tickets. An affable OBC chief minister in Nayab Singh Saini helped heal the bruises left by an abrasive Manohar Lal Khattar. Most of all, the RSS was back in the field, silently activated, mounting a low-decibel, targeted campaign. Groups of 150 volunteers, formed for every constituency, held about 100 small meetings a week. All these are replicable tactics. What RSS sah-sarkaryavah Arun Kumar did in Haryana has been entrusted to his colleagues Atul Limaye and Alok Kumar in Maharashtra and Jharkhand respectively.



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Meanwhile, the Congress is under fire from its INDIA partners—especially Uddhav Thackeray's Shiv Sena, which now eyes a better hand in seat allocation. For good reason. Rahul Gandhi's party stares at another botched exam. It allowed Hooda's factional monopoly to scare away non-Jat OBCs and Dalits. A sulking Kumari Selja meant the BJP sliced away eight of 17 reserved seats. When the Hindu/Muslim binary was stark, in both Jammu and Haryana, the Congress found that Hindutva isn't entirely a dated cheque. Moreover, it picked up only five of Haryana's 25 urban seats against the BJP's 18, betraying the need for more variety in its political outreach. Maharashtra's populace, after all, is 45 per cent urban.

The battle in J&K was, of course, not over an ordinary assembly election. It's unique in India: what happens in Kashmir by definition runs on more rarefied terrain, with long-term national and geopolitical import. But the outcome holds sobering lessons for both sides. The BJP's complex tactical play in the Valley, outsourcing responsibility to a variety of King's parties and Independents, flopped. That it won a solid 29 seats in core Jammu areas, decimating the Congress, will not minimise the grief. The bottom line is that, even after a decade of control, and even with a more favourable skew in seat delimitation, its ambition of anointing the first BJP chief minister ever in J&K lies thwarted. That mantle will go to Omar Abdullah, whose National Conference returned an impressive score of 42 in the new 90-seat assembly. With batting partner Congress adding six seats, he has a comfortable majority.

What's far less comfortable is the challenge that awaits Omar. In his second stint as CM, he is the lord of not just a lesser realm, truncated and downgraded, but a lesser government. Newly amended rules bestow on the Lieutenant Governor even more administrative and legal powers, including control over law and order via the transfer of IAS/ IPS and J&K Police officers, appointment of high judicial officers like the Advocate General, the Anti-Corruption Bureau, prosecution matters and prisons. As Omar puts it, "In my first innings, I was CM of the most empowered state. But now J&K is the country's most disempowered Union Territory." Some of the promises Omar made to the electorate, especially pressing for restoration of Article 370, will therefore yield only rhetorical value. Even fulfilling the more achievable goals, like restoration of statehood and reservation of land and job rights for locals, will be daunting in the absence of a working relationship with New Delhi. This week, we analyse the assembly poll results with this future orientation. Call Round 1 fifty-fifty.

On a sadder note, the passing away of Ratan Tata, the iconic former chairman of India's largest conglomerate, is a time to pay tribute to this compassionate visionary. In an interview to INDIA TODAY in 2008, when he launched Nano, the people's car priced at Rs 1 lakh, Tata observed, "If we dispense with some of our self-made boundaries, India can really take its place in the world as an economic power. It hasn't happened because, sadly, we don't look at ourselves as Indians but as Punjabis or Parsis, unlike Americans." That message still holds good, as do his contributions to India's economic growth.

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